Singapore. Five years later, he was appointed in a ‘19-member group of notables’ to assist the UK government to prepare strategies for the city of London.

Greenberg talks about how when Ratan was on the International Advisory Board of AIG, along with Kissinger and ex-Prime Minister of Thailand Khun Anand Panyarachun, ‘They all admired him on the Advisory Board. I think that Ratan was an inspiration to all Indians as well as the members [of the board]. He was a very valuable asset. … [He is a] terrific man, a terrific man,’ he gushes. Recalling the contribution Ratan makes during meetings, Venu Srinivasan says that he comes ‘carefully’ and ‘meticulously’ prepared for meetings and virtually sets the agenda of the discussions. When he spoke, ‘the world stopped and listened’. Venu adds: ‘I have seen that in the Prime Minister’s meeting, Manmohan Singh would come and then say, you know Mr Tata would you start first and he gave just the backdrop, and the rest of the meeting took place like the cinema set on the backdrop that he creates; everybody else spoke but it was part of the backdrop that he created.’

Gordon Brown, former UK Prime Minister, whose government was not initially forthcoming with its support for the Tata Group, ended up acknowledging and applauding ‘on behalf of so many people’, Ratan’s contribution across the globe.

In 2005, Ratan was made the co-chair of the India–US CEO Forum. Appreciating his contribution, George W. Bush, former President of the USA, wrote to Ratan in 2006, thanking him for his ‘input and help in shaping its [the forum’s] future’.

His stature also saw Ratan on the boards of several reputed companies around the world. Besides AIG, he was on the International Advisory Boards of Mitsubishi Corporation, JP Morgan Chase and Booz-Allen Hamilton and the Board of Trustees of the Ford Foundation.

Ratan’s contribution to Mitsubishi was specially recognized. He was closely associated with Minoru Makihara, president and CEO of Mitsubishi Corporation in 1992 and later its chairman (1998–2004). Ratan served ‘as an outside member’ of the International Advisory Committee of Mitsubishi since its inception in 2001. The committee accepted virtually all of Ratan’s suggestions, including the stationing of an executive at its Silicon Valley branch. After Ratan advised Mitsubishi to ‘pay close attention to Indian consumption’, India’s middle class ‘[experienced] explosive growth’ and